What Is Stoicism?

What would it mean to live well, whatever happens to you?

READING · 10 MINUTES

Stoicism 101. Give a short talk in your own words, drawing on Stoicism 101, or watch this five-minute video together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 15	Read · 10	Discuss · 40	Practice · 10	Close · 15
Ground rules; names and what brought you	Your short talk or the video	The questions below	Introduce it	Agree on a regular day and time

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Before tonight, what did you think “stoic” meant? What surprised you?
2. The Stoics said a good life depends on character, not circumstances. Do you believe that?
3. Think of someone you admire for how they handle hardship. What do they actually do?
4. Wisdom, courage, justice, temperance: which comes easiest to you? Which is hardest?
5. What would make a group like this worth your time each month?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Evening review. Each night, ask: What went well? What didn’t? What will I do differently tomorrow?

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“What do you mean by…?” When someone says *good* or *happy*, ask them to define it first.

NOTES

What's Actually Good?

If money, health, and reputation aren't the goal, what is?

READING · THREE PAGES

Plato, *Euthydemus* 278e–282e. Socrates argues that wealth and health only benefit us when they're used wisely, so wisdom is what makes anything good.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	**Discuss · 45**	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	**The questions below**	Try it on a real choice	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Name three things you want most. Why do you want them?
2. Can wealth or health ever harm someone? How?
3. Socrates says wisdom is what makes other things useful. Do you agree?
4. The Stoics called money and health "preferred indifferents." What's gained and lost in that view?
5. Looking back on your meetings so far, what's one idea you've actually used?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

The wise-person test. Before a decision, ask: what would a wise person do here, and why?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Bring back the control question: are the things you want most up to you?

NOTES

A Deeper Introduction

What did the Stoics actually believe, and why?

READING · ONE OR TWO SECTIONS

Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Stoicism." A little dense, but rich and readable. Too long for one meeting? Pick one or two sections.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. If you plan to read *How to Be a Stoic* next, tell members now so they can get a copy.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Choose your sentence	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which idea in the article surprised you most?
2. The Stoics tied ethics to their physics and logic. Does how you see the world change how you should live?
3. Which idea from our first six months does the article help explain?
4. What would you still push back on?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One sentence. Pick one sentence from the article that matters to you, and reread it each morning.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What do you mean by…?" Words like *nature* and *reason* meant something specific to the Stoics.

NOTES

The Four Virtues

What does a good person actually do?

READING · ONE PARAGRAPH

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 3.6. If you find anything in life better than justice, truth, self-control, and courage, Marcus says, turn to it with all your heart. He doubts you will.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Pick tomorrow's virtue	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Think of someone you admire. Which of the four virtues do you see in them?
2. Marcus ranks virtue above everything else in life. What would you be tempted to put above it?
3. Can someone be brave without being wise? Honest without being kind?
4. Which virtue does your work or family life ask of you most?
5. Where did you practice one of them this week, even in a small way?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One virtue a day. Each morning, pick one virtue to practice. Each evening, note one moment you did.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What do you mean by…?" Ask the group to define courage or justice before debating it.

NOTES

ABOUT 90 MINUTES

What's in My Control?

Why do we spend so much energy on things we can't change?

READING · ONE PAGE

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1. Some things are up to us: our judgments, intentions, and actions. Others aren't: our bodies, reputations, and other people.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question above and a link to the reading.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Try it on a real worry	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. List what worried you this week. Which items were fully up to you?
2. Is your health in your control? Your job? Where exactly is the line?
3. If outcomes aren't up to us, why try at all?
4. What changes when you aim at your effort rather than the result?
5. Where could this idea go wrong if it's taken too far?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Mine / not mine. Once a day, split a worry into the part that's yours and the part that isn't. Act only on yours.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" When someone says something is out of their control, ask how they'd tell.

NOTES

When Your Mind Jumps to Conclusions

What am I being asked to believe — and what supports it?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1, especially its closing instruction; **Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 8.49**. Epictetus asks us to examine impressions and what is up to us. Marcus separates what is reported from what we add. An impression is how something appears; assent accepts what it presents as true.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack a week ahead with the question and reading links. Invite an ordinary example of a quick conclusion. Newcomers need no preparation.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	**Discuss · 40**	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	Test a message with no reply	**The questions below**	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. An important message has no reply. What do you know, and what might your mind add?
2. Which impressions feel most convincing before you examine them? Why?
3. What judgment or intention belongs to you, and what depends on someone else?
4. What evidence would justify accepting, rejecting, or leaving a conclusion unsettled?
5. If your first judgment stands after examination, what did the practice accomplish?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Test one impression. When certainty or urgency arrives, name the impression, separate what you know from what you infer, and decide what the grounds support. The judgment may stand, change, or stay unsettled. If you notice only afterward, you can still reopen it.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What supports that?" Ask it of reassuring interpretations too. The Fundamental Rule identifies your judgment and intention; another person's response still deserves care.

NOTES

Anger

Is it the thing that happened, or what I tell myself about it?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 5: we aren't disturbed by things, but by our judgments about them. **Seneca, *On Anger* 2.4** (Book II, chapter 4): anger comes in three movements: an involuntary jolt, a judgment we agree to, and a passion we can't control. We can step in at the second.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask people to notice one moment of irritation during the week.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Rewrite one judgment	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Recall a recent moment of anger. What happened, and what did you tell yourself about it?
2. Seneca says the first jolt isn't up to us, but agreeing to it is. In your example, where could you have stepped in?
3. Seneca thought anger is never useful. Do you agree?
4. What's the difference between anger and a firm, fair response?
5. What would a pause change: counting, walking away, sleeping on it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Catch the second movement. When you feel the jolt, finish the sentence "I'm telling myself that…" before you act. Then ask whether it's true.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Talk about anger stays vague until someone describes a real moment.

NOTES

Worry About the Future

Do we suffer more from what happens, or from what we imagine?

READING · TWO PAGES

Seneca, Letter 13 (“On Groundless Fears”). Many fears never arrive; Seneca asks whether a feared evil is certain before we suffer it.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Link the letter; reading it ahead is optional.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Five quiet minutes	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What future event takes up the most room in your head right now?
2. Think of past worries. How many happened the way you feared?
3. Seneca asks whether the evil is certain. Is that comforting, or dismissive?
4. What’s the difference between planning and worrying?
5. How could calmly imagining the worst help rather than hurt?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Rehearse a setback. For five minutes, calmly picture something going wrong, and plan how you’d respond well.

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“If that’s true, what follows?” Walk a worry forward, step by step, to see where it really leads.

NOTES

When a Difficulty Becomes a Disaster

What is the difficulty — and what am I predicting it means?

READING

Seneca, *Letters* 13.4–12; **Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 4**. Seneca examines anticipated troubles and the evidence for them. Epictetus prepares for familiar obstacles while preserving sound choice. Preparation acknowledges a possibility; it does not establish that the feared event will happen.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite an ordinary worry about a task or conversation. Personal crises need not become discussion examples.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Welcome; passing is fine	Selected passages aloud	A difficult presentation: facts vs. predictions	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Before a difficult presentation, which problems are known and which are predictions?
2. How do discomfort, uncertainty, or embarrassment affect the confidence you give a judgment?
3. What evidence would support the feared conclusion — and what would weaken it?
4. How does rehearsing one realistic obstacle differ from repeatedly imagining disaster?
5. If the difficulty is real, what remains yours to judge without minimizing the risk?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Name the difficulty precisely. In one pressured situation, state the present facts, name the prediction or evaluation added, and decide what the evidence supports. You may also rehearse one likely obstacle and a sound response. Leave unsupported predictions open.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What is happening now?" Separate current evidence from a future story. A more cheerful forecast needs evidence too; reasonable precautions can proceed under uncertainty.

NOTES

Before You Judge Someone

What did this person do — and what have I added?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 45 and 43. The first passage separates description from judgments that need further knowledge. The second acknowledges a brother's injustice while recalling their relationship. A fuller perspective must be true and relevant; it need not excuse misconduct or restore trust.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Ask for anonymous examples. Members may use the fictional case instead of a personal conflict.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Ground rules; no identifying details	Aloud, together	A colleague misses a deadline	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. A colleague misses an agreed deadline. What is established, and what remains uncertain?
2. When does a judgment about conduct become a verdict about the whole person?
3. What other true and relevant perspective would help you understand this conflict fairly?
4. Can a justified grievance acquire an additional verdict that payback would be good?
5. What remains owed to a fellow human being when an adverse judgment is justified?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Separate conduct from verdict. When judging someone, describe the conduct, name the further conclusion, and examine its grounds. Recall a relevant relationship or shared humanity without inventing a reassuring motive. Keep warranted criticism; revise what exceeds the evidence.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Which judgment are we examining?" Distinguish misconduct, motive, personal worth, and payback. Understanding a person does not settle what response justice requires.

NOTES

When Wanting Turns Into Needing

Can I pursue this seriously without making a good life depend on getting it?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 2 and 4. Desire and aversion promise getting or escaping something. At the baths, Epictetus's governing aim is to preserve sound choice. Preferred indifferents such as health and security deserve care; virtue determines whether we use them well.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite members to notice a preference that feels like a requirement. A general example is enough.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional January observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Preference or requirement?	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What does something you want promise to give you — or protect you from?
2. How can you tell when a preference becomes something that must happen?
3. If the external goal stays the same, what changes when character governs the pursuit?
4. Can an unwanted outcome bring a real loss without making living well impossible?
5. Once the facts are settled, what would willingness to meet them mean without approving them?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Prefer without requiring. Choose one recurring want. Name its practical value, the condition you have attached to living well, and what stays worth wanting either way. When the demand returns, ask: **"Am I preferring this, or requiring it?"**

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Necessary for what?" Separate an actual practical need from a claim about the possibility of a good life. Allow disappointment and difficult answers.

NOTES

How Much Is Enough?

What would satisfy the need — and why do I still want more?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 15; Seneca, *Letters* 23.1–8. Epictetus's banquet image trains moderation in receiving and waiting for externals. Seneca directs joy toward sound purpose and conduct. We examine dependence on more and what we are learning to value.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Invite members to notice an expanding "enough": possessions, praise, convenience, or certainty. Nobody needs to discuss finances.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional October observation	Selected passages aloud	The questions below	Define enough in one area	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. In one area of life, what would enough provide? What keeps moving the threshold?
2. At the banquet, what changes when you receive your share without treating the table as yours?
3. How could simplifying one convenience reveal whether you depend on it?
4. What gladness comes from sound judgment or goodwill rather than getting another external reward?
5. How can you appreciate ordinary advantages without making them conditions of living well?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Name enough. Choose one recurring want and state what would reasonably serve its purpose. When the threshold expands, examine what "more" promises; simplifying one small area can test the dependence. Notice what remains worth welcoming; no cheerful mood is required.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Enough for what purpose?" Needs differ with circumstances and responsibilities. Examine the reason for the threshold rather than ranking people by how little they own.

NOTES

Before You Give In

What is this pleasure promising — and do I have grounds to agree?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 34 and *Discourses* 4.12.1–5. Epictetus advises delay and considering pleasure's aftermath. His account of attention also includes play and song. We apply these ideas to examining a compelling promise; enjoyment can still be a reasonable choice.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the reading links. Invite an ordinary example: scrolling, shopping, or another episode. No private habit needs to be disclosed.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Welcome; no confessions required	Aloud, together	Test the promise of one more episode	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. When an urge says "one more," what exactly is it asking you to believe?
2. What would a brief delay let you examine that the urge leaves out?
3. How can you consider the aftermath without assuming all enjoyment leads to regret?
4. What captures your attention repeatedly, and how does that shape what seems worth choosing?
5. When might a limit chosen in advance help judgment — and when should you reconsider it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Examine the promise. Pause in one recurring temptation, name the promised benefit, and consider the choice now and afterward. Accept, revise, or decline on grounds you can explain; an advance limit can help you remember them. Pleasure alone does not settle it.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What is the claim?" Find the judgment inside "I need this now." Passing on pleasure is not automatically progress; more careful examination is.

NOTES

What Am I Trying Never to Face?

What am I treating as something that must never happen?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 2; Seneca, *Letters* 18.5–8. Epictetus redirects aversion toward misusing our own choice. Seneca rehearses simple living to examine dependence on comfort and wealth. This modern adaptation uses a modest, safe inconvenience to inspect what we think we need.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Say the topic includes fear, comfort, and dependence. Nobody must disclose a loss or undertake discomfort. Bring the reading links.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Welcome; anyone may pass	Aloud, together	The questions below	Test a small supposed necessity	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What inconvenience do you work hard to prevent? What would facing it seem to mean?
2. When does sensible avoidance become a demand for complete protection from difficulty?
3. What might going briefly without a convenience reveal that thinking alone misses?
4. How can knowing life is finite clarify what is worth wanting without making us gloomy?
5. In difficulty, what misuse of your own choice deserves more concern than discomfort?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Examine one aversion. Name what you want to avoid and why escape seems necessary. If suitable, try one harmless inconvenience, such as setting aside entertainment while waiting, and notice what it reveals about dependence. A recent unavoidable one works as well; no endurance contest is needed.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What are we testing?" Keep the focus on valuation. Choose ordinary discomfort that fits health and responsibilities; there is no need for deprivation or proof of toughness.

NOTES

ABOUT 90 MINUTES

Grief and Loss

How do we love what we know we will lose?

READING · TWO SHORT CHAPTERS

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 3 and 11. Remember that what you love is mortal. And of anything you lose, never say “I have lost it,” but “I have restored it.”

BEFORE THE MEETING

Grief can be raw. In the announcement, say the topic plainly, and at the meeting let anyone pass on personal examples.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; anyone may pass	Aloud, together	The questions below	Returned, not lost	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Epictetus says to remember that what we love is mortal. Is that comforting or cold?
2. What’s the difference between “I lost it” and “I restored it”?
3. Can a Stoic grieve? What would healthy Stoic grief look like?
4. How can we value someone fully while accepting they’re on loan?
5. If you’re willing to share: what helped you most in a past loss?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Returned, not lost. When you lose something small this month, a pen or an opportunity, practice saying “it was returned.”

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“Is that always true?” Gently test absolute claims, like “you never get over it.”

NOTES

What Others Think

Why do we care so much about opinions we don't respect?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 13: if you want to improve, be content to seem foolish.

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 12.4: we love ourselves more than anyone, yet value others' opinions of us more than our own.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above and links to both passages.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Spot one choice made for show	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Whose opinion of you matters most, and why?
2. Marcus noticed we value others' opinions of us above our own. Is that true for you?
3. When is reputation worth caring about, and when isn't it?
4. What would you do differently if no one would ever know?
5. Epictetus says to be content to seem foolish. Where might that be good advice for you right now?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Reputation as an indifferent. Once a day, notice a choice made for appearances. Ask what you'd choose if no one saw.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" When someone says "everyone thinks…", ask what they actually know.

NOTES

Difficult People

How do I stay decent toward people who make it hard?

READING · ONE PARAGRAPH

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 2.1. Each morning he expects to meet rude, ungrateful people, reminds himself they act from ignorance, and that we're made to work together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Remind people to keep examples anonymous: no names, no workplaces.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; keep it anonymous	Aloud, twice	The questions below	Write your own 2.1	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Marcus expects difficult people every morning. Is that pessimistic or practical?
2. Think of someone who frustrates you. What might they believe that makes their behavior make sense to them?
3. Does understanding someone mean excusing them?
4. In that relationship, what is actually in your control?
5. What does justice ask of you toward people you don't like?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Morning preparation. Before work, say your own version of 2.1: who you might meet today, and how you want to treat them.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that always true?" When someone says "people like that never change," invite a counterexample.

NOTES

Knowing What to Do—and Doing It

What does this situation call for from me?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 30; Musonius Rufus, Lecture 5, "Which Is More Effective, Theory or Practice?" Relationships help identify responsibilities; Musonius puts practice ahead of explanation. An appropriate action is one you can reasonably justify. If obstructed, a different response may fit.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask members to notice one responsibility they understand but find hard to carry out. Nobody needs a journal or prior lessons.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional February observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Give a virtue an action	One practice to retain

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. In an ordinary responsibility, what makes an action fitting rather than merely convenient?
2. How does being a friend, colleague, parent, or neighbor clarify your part?
3. When someone else fails in their role, what changes about yours?
4. If your plan is blocked, what concrete action could express the virtue now required?
5. Looking across judgment, desire, and action, what small practice is worth retaining?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Give it an action. Choose one recurring responsibility. Identify what matters, decide **"I will ___ because ___,"** and take the next step. Repeat when it recurs; adapt when circumstances change. Assess your reasons and follow-through, not others' cooperation.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What would that look like?" Turn "be patient" or "be responsible" into conduct someone could describe. A useful answer may include a refusal or boundary.

NOTES

Making Room for Other People

Whose good is missing from what I want?

READING

Seneca, *Letters* 48.1–3; Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 5.6. Seneca links friendship with shared interests. Marcus separates helping from keeping account of what others owe. We examine whom our desires include and what return we require.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Invite members to notice a shared decision where their preference affects someone else. Include a reading link; preparation is optional.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional April observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Widen a meeting-time preference	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. In a shared choice, whose interests do you include — and whose are easy to overlook?
2. What would you hope for an overlooked person if someone close to you were in their place?
3. How could taking those interests seriously change what you want, even if your preference remains?
4. When you contribute, what recognition are you waiting for before it feels worthwhile?
5. If someone declines your help, can their welfare remain important without their compliance?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Give the want a wider aim. Before one shared choice, name your preference and an overlooked legitimate interest, then finish: **"I want ___ while taking ___ seriously."** Keep that concern without praise or agreement. No extra good deed is required.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Who else is affected?" Include someone who bears a cost without being present. Fair concern includes your own legitimate needs; it does not guarantee a compromise.

NOTES

Doing Your Part

What contribution is mine to make?

READING

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 8.12 and **10.4**. Marcus directs attention to communal benefit and to correction that shows an error without hostility. Justice gives us reasons to seek fitting contributions as well as examine how we act and speak.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite members to notice a small unmet need in a shared undertaking. No promise to volunteer is expected.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional May observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Turn a need into a bounded contribution	One practice to retain

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What useful contribution might go undone because nobody has been asked?
2. How do role, ability, and existing responsibilities help determine your part?
3. What would make the proposed contribution honest, fair, and useful to the people affected?
4. If correction is needed, how can you make the request clear without adding contempt?
5. What have fairer judgments, wider concern, and just action taught you about living with others?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Seek one fitting contribution. In a setting you already belong to, notice a real need, check your role and limits, and complete one bounded contribution. Ask before helping when consent matters. Learn and adapt if the help misses its mark; appreciation is not the measure.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Does this fit the actual need?" Test the contribution from the recipient's side. Service may involve asking, correcting, referring, or stepping back.

NOTES

Doing the Right Thing When It Is Hard

What responsibility deserves my steadiness now?

READING

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 5.1 and 5.9. Marcus recalls his work as a human being and urges a return to sound principles after falling short. Courage sustains fitting conduct through difficulty; changing the method may help preserve the responsibility.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question and reading links. Invite a modest example, such as a needed conversation. No dramatic courage required.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Optional August observation	Aloud, together	The questions below	Rehearse one difficult next step	One practice to retain

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What makes a responsibility worth continuing when motivation fades?
2. When is persistence fitting, and when do rest, help, or a changed plan better serve it?
3. What needs saying in a difficult conversation, and how can you say it fairly?
4. After a mistake, what separates renewed effort from excuses or self-condemnation?
5. How have examining threats and aversions helped you act when the right thing has a cost?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Take the next fitting step. Choose one worthwhile responsibility and take its next concrete action when the occasion comes. If blocked or mistaken, correct what you can and choose the next step. Steadiness can include changing course; assess conduct, not applause.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Steady toward what?" Test the purpose before encouraging perseverance. Courage remains answerable to wisdom, justice, and temperance.

NOTES

The Three Disciplines

How do you practice Stoicism, not just think about it?

READING · TWO SHORT ARTICLES

Donald Robertson, "Introduction to Stoicism: The Three Disciplines" and "A Simplified Modern Approach to Stoicism." Epictetus taught through desire, action, and judgment.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with links to both articles.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Pick a daily practice	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Desire, action, and judgment: which discipline do you most need right now?
2. Which practices from earlier months fit under each discipline?
3. What gets in the way of daily practice for you?
4. How could this group help you keep at it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One daily practice. Choose one practice from Robertson's simplified approach and keep it all month.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Can you give an example?" Ask for a moment this week when one of the disciplines would have helped.

NOTES

How to Be a Stoic, Part One

What does a modern Stoic life look like?

READING · FIRST HALF OF THE BOOK

Massimo Pigliucci, *How to Be a Stoic*. Modern Stoic theory and practice, organized around Epictetus' three disciplines.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Remind members which chapters to read. Some will only get partway; that's fine.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	A favorite passage each	The questions below	Start the journal	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which of Pigliucci's examples comes closest to your own life?
2. Where does a modern reading change what Epictetus meant?
3. Where do you disagree with the author?
4. What would you ask him if he were here?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

A one-line journal. Each evening, write one line: where did you practice Stoicism today, and where did you miss?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" Test the book's claims against members' own experience.

NOTES

How to Be a Stoic, Part Two

Which Stoic exercise is worth keeping?

READING · SECOND HALF OF THE BOOK

Pigliucci, *How to Be a Stoic*, second half. The last chapter is a guide to basic Stoic exercises, a natural bridge into practice.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Ask members to come ready to pick an exercise to try together next month.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	A favorite passage each	The questions below	Choose next month's exercise	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which exercise in the final chapter appeals to you most? Which least?
2. Has your view of Stoicism changed since you started? How?
3. What does the book get right about living well that we haven't discussed?
4. Which exercise should we try together next month?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

One exercise. Choose one exercise from the final chapter and try it daily.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that always true?" Test a favorite idea from the book against a hard case.

NOTES

Seneca on Saving Time

Where does your time actually go?

READING · ONE LETTER

Seneca, Letter 1 (“On Saving Time”). Most of our time is taken from us, stolen, or simply slips away. Seneca urges Lucilius to hold on to every hour. A good first letter for a group that wants to read Seneca together.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Link the letter in your announcement and ask members to read it beforehand. It’s about two pages.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Key passages aloud	The questions below	Plan one hour	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Seneca says time is taken, stolen, or slips away. Which is most true for you?
2. He says we are dying every day. What changes if you take that seriously?
3. Is being busy a problem, or a badge of honor?
4. What would “holding every hour” look like in your week?
5. If the group read one letter a month, what theme would you want next?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Claim an hour. Once a day, before an hour begins, decide what it’s for. Notice where it went.

FACILITATOR’S MOVE

“Can you give an example?” Ask for a specific hour this week that slipped away.

NOTES

A Practice Session

What happens when we practice together, not just talk?

INSTEAD OF A READING

Do the exercise together. Lead the exercise the group chose last month, such as the evening review, rehearsing a setback, or the view from above. More ideas in our practice resources.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack which exercise you'll do, so members can try it during the week.

Open · 10	Practice · 15	Discuss · 45	Plan · 10	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	The exercise, together	The questions below	How we'll keep it up	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What did you notice during the exercise?
2. Was it harder or easier than you expected? Why?
3. Which practices have you kept up this year, and which did you drop?
4. How could the group support each other's practice between meetings?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Keep it going. Continue the exercise all month, and note one thing it changed.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"If that's true, what follows?" Follow each person's observation one step further.

NOTES

Examine Your Impressions

Is it true, or does it just feel true?

READING · ONE LINE, THEN AN EXERCISE

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 1 (the last lines): meet every harsh impression by reminding yourself it is only an impression, not necessarily what it appears to be. Then test it. See the wiki's Examine Your Impressions.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Ask members to bring one recent moment when a first reaction turned out to be wrong.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	Test one impression together	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What impression hit you hardest this week? What was it asking you to believe?
2. When you got it wrong, was the error in the facts, the value you placed on something, or the action you took?
3. Which impressions win you over fastest: fear, pleasure, urgency, or authority?
4. Epictetus pictures a night watchman asking each impression to show its pass. What would your pass check?
5. What short question could you ask yourself in the moment?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Show me your pass. Before acting on a strong reaction, ask: What am I being asked to believe? What supports it? What can I endorse?

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"How would you know?" It's the heart of this exercise. Use it on the group's examples.

NOTES

Accepting What Happens

What are you still arguing with?

READING · TWO SHORT PASSAGES

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 8: don't demand that things happen as you wish; wish them to happen as they do. **Seneca, Letter 107:** fate leads the willing and drags the unwilling. See the wiki's Accepting Reality.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the question above. Ask members to think of one thing they wish had gone differently.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 45	Practice · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Aloud, together	The questions below	Name it, release it	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What event are you still arguing with in your head?
2. Is accepting something the same as approving of it?
3. Seneca says fate leads the willing and drags the unwilling. Which have you been lately?
4. Can acceptance turn into passivity? Where's the line?
5. What became possible the last time you stopped resisting something?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Accepting reality. When an "if only" starts, name the fact plainly, notice what you're demanding, and ask what virtue requires now.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Separate what's already happened from what's still yours to choose.

NOTES

A Practice You Can Keep

What deserves a lasting place in the way I live?

READING

Seneca, *Letters* 20.1–5; **Epictetus, *Discourses* 3.2.1–5**. Seneca seeks agreement between principles and conduct. Epictetus distinguishes training in desire, action, and assent. Use these fields to find a practice that helps in a real recurring situation; keep the commitment sustainable.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack. Invite one remembered practice or question worth retaining. Notes are optional; newcomers may choose something useful from tonight's discussion.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Discuss · 40	Practice · 20	Close · 10
Welcome; recognize shared learning	Aloud, together	The questions below	Build a one-sentence practice rule	One contribution each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which practice helped you notice or do something differently in ordinary life?
2. What difficulty remains, and which field — judgment, desire, or action — needs attention?
3. When two legitimate responsibilities compete, how can one ethical standard guide different responses?
4. What would make your chosen practice realistic on a crowded day?
5. What did someone in this group help you notice that you might have missed alone?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Give practice a place. Finish: **"When ___, I will use ___ to ___."** Choose one useful practice and an ordinary cue. Try it, then review whether it fits the situation and your responsibilities. If you miss an occasion, resume at the next. Add more only when there is a reason.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What changed in the example?" Seek evidence without demanding improvement. Mixed results can clarify what to keep, adapt, or let go.

NOTES

Looking Back, Looking Ahead

What has a year of Stoicism changed?

INSTEAD OF A READING

Bring a passage. Each member brings one passage from the year that stayed with them and reads it aloud.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack and ask everyone to bring a passage. This is the meeting where you plan year two.

Open · 10	Share · 20	Discuss · 35	Plan · 15	Close · 10
Ground rules; welcome newcomers	Passages read aloud	The questions below	Choose year two's format	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Which idea have you used most this year?
2. What still feels hard to practice?
3. What kept you coming back?
4. What should our second year look like? See Topics and Formats for options.

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

A letter to yourself. As Seneca wrote to Lucilius, write a short letter to yourself to reread a year from now.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"Is that in your control?" Ask what each person can keep doing, whatever the group decides.

NOTES